



To a better future: The end of a two-decade wait and an unexpected triumph for the side are all nudges for the administration to keep improving the ecosystem of the island nation. AP

ninth. I think this opportunity to represent your country on the world stage is something that should be really special to every single player at this tournament," she had said then.

Job well done

Hours after partying well into the night, the White Ferns were up and about in Dubai, some cycling down boulevards, others still in their jerseys with medals on, soaking in the sunrise at the Marina. New Zealand and Devine, at the top, have all earned the right to let the dam break and for the tears to flow.

The end of a two-decade wait and an unexpected triumph for the side are all nudges for the administration to keep improving the ecosystem of the island nation.

But the standout image from the celebrations that followed that last ball was a long, tight hug between Bates and Devine (**right**), which took fans straight to memories of Rohit Sharma and Virat Kohli's emotional embrace after India won the men's trophy earlier this year, beating South Africa in a nervy final.

"We've fought our way back to the top," Bates told broadcasters a few minutes later. "Devine has been so outstanding leading this team... so calm and believing in us. We'll

probably have a cuddle for even longer later because there have been some dark times that only the people in the team understand."

A day later, during the captain's photoshoot at the Dubai Marina, Devine reflected on a deeply satisfying end to her tenure as New Zealand captain.

"That was probably 17-18 years' worth of emotions, of highs and lows. I think the team has seen a slightly softer side of me this trip. With the realisation that I am not going to captain anymore ... still being involved with the team and what not moving forward... but I just let them in a little bit more... As captain, you can sometimes be a little aloof. For me, it was about letting those shackles go and being a bit more cuddly. Showing that softer side is important as a leader. It's important to be vulnerable and to show your side every part. I have got that back in truckloads from this team. There's a lot of care — whether we won or not — in this unit. It makes this team special and always will."

That Devine's side, long-time advocate for equal pay in sports and champion of equal pay as board policy, won the edition where the men and women earned the same prize money is the perfect way to wrap up this World Cup.

Bates had hoped to give her old friend and comrade Devine a special send-off by reaching the semifinal. The White Ferns went on to make the final and win quite spectacularly. Some fairytales do come true!

